

job and in no time I'll pay that off. The problem is, young people in this country are discovering that the job market isn't always greeting them with open arms after they pick up their degrees. And if they do get jobs, they're often not in their field of study, or are entry-level positions that don't pay all that much. So many young graduates are trapped in that awful place where their debt is growing faster than their ability to pay it off. Their student loan becomes this ugly thing that follows them around after college and right into their first marriages. The loan gets in the way of buying a car or a house. It's just always *there*. Lucky you if Mom and Dad socked away enough money for your postsecondary education and you were perfectly happy to live at home for those four years, saving a ton of money. That's not the reality for most students. More than half of students in postsecondary school will graduate with debt.

Nursing, law, dentistry degrees—all these are good investments, because these degrees generally mean a well-paying job is in the offing upon graduation, one that'll help you tackle the hideous debt you'll accumulate before graduation. But again, like any investment, even those so-called sure things are risky.

What about a general liberal arts degree? It's nice to have, but it's not a great investment, because there's often no clear-cut job waiting for you at the end, since you haven't learned a real, tangible skill, like surgery or accounting. I say this as someone with an undergraduate degree in psychology and environmental studies. College was fun. I learned a lot. But I was completely unprepared for the job market when I graduated. Lucky for me, my parents were paying for my education, so I didn't graduate \$60,000 in debt after studying trees and bones for four years. Luckier still, my stepfather sat me down and convinced me that an MBA would save my bacon after blowing four years pursuing my interests.

This will be an unpopular statement, but I am directly addressing it to young people who are paying out of pocket for their education: Imagine the end result of your degree and plan backward. Fine arts might be your passion, but consider the kind of work you want to do when you graduate, because the cold hard truth is that for much of your adult life, you're going to be working, so it better be doing